

Chapter 4: *The Café Rule: Don't Let Anyone Order for You*

She got the job interview callback the next morning.

Or at least that's what the email said.

She read it three times.

Then a fourth time, slower, like the words might change their tone.

"We would like to proceed with the next stage..."

She exhaled so loudly it scared her own thoughts.

Mia was already in the kitchen.

"That's advancement," Mia said.

"That's not a job yet."

"It's the emotional equivalent of a handshake."

She frowned. "That doesn't make sense."

Mia nodded. "It rarely does in employment."

Mia insisted they celebrate.

"Not too much," she added immediately. "We are still financially fragile."

"So... what are we doing?"

"Café."

Of course.

Mia always chose café.

It was like she had a personal agreement with caffeine culture.

The café was warm, busy, slightly too loud in a comforting way.

She liked places like this.

Places where other people's lives made her feel less alone in her own.

They sat by the window.

Mia immediately leaned back like she owned the chair.

"You're in a good mood," she said.

"I got a second interview."

"I know."

She paused. "You always know immediately."

Mia shrugged. "I pay attention."

That sounded normal.

Too normal.

She picked up the menu.

"What are you ordering?" she asked.

Mia didn't take the menu.

Didn't even look at it.

"I'm not ordering."

She blinked. "Why not?"

Mia smiled faintly.

"Because I shouldn't."

"That's not an answer."

“It’s a rule.”

She leaned forward slightly. “Since when do you have rules about ordering coffee?”

Mia looked out the window.

For a second, she didn’t answer.

Then:

“Since I started noticing patterns.”

The words should have meant nothing.

But something in her stomach tightened anyway.

She tried to laugh it off.

“You’re being weird again.”

Mia smiled. “I’m always weird. You just usually don’t pay attention.”

“I’m paying attention now.”

“That’s what I’m afraid of.”

The waiter arrived.

Looked at her.

“Are you ready to order?”

She nodded.

“I’ll have an iced coffee.”

The waiter turned slightly.

“And for your friend?”

Silence.

A small, ordinary silence.

Then she said automatically, “She’ll have—”

Mia interrupted immediately.

“I’ll order myself later.”

The waiter paused.

Looked at her.

Then nodded politely and left.

She frowned.

“You don’t usually do that,” she said.

Mia tilted her head. “Do what?”

“Stop me from ordering for you.”

Mia shrugged. “It’s unnecessary.”

“That’s not the point.”

Mia leaned forward slightly.

“What is the point?”

She hesitated.

Then said:

“It feels like you don’t want to be... included.”

That landed differently.

Mia didn’t joke.

Didn’t deflect.

Just looked at her for a moment.

Then softly:

“I don’t want you to lose control of what’s yours.”

That should have sounded comforting.

But instead—

it felt specific.

Too specific.

Like it wasn’t about coffee at all.

Later, when their drinks arrived, she noticed something odd.

The waiter placed one drink on the table.

Only one.

“I ordered two,” she said quickly.

The waiter frowned politely. “Just the iced coffee, right?”

She froze.

“No. Two.”

The waiter glanced at the table.

Then back at her.

“There’s only one order on the system.”

Mia leaned back casually.

“Must be a mistake.”

Her voice was normal.

Too normal.

She stared at the empty space across from her.

Then at Mia.

“Mia,” she said quietly.

“Yes?”

“Did you hear him?”

Mia smiled.

“I heard you.”

“That’s not what I asked.”

Mia took a slow sip of air—like she was pretending to drink something invisible.

Then said gently:

“You don’t need everything confirmed to enjoy it.”

Her coffee suddenly didn’t taste right.

Not bad.

Just... uncertain.

On the way home, she couldn’t stop thinking about it.

“One drink,” she said.

Mia hummed.

“Only one.”

Mia nodded. “Yes.”

“That wasn’t normal.”

“What part?”

“The waiter didn’t see you.”

Mia didn’t answer immediately.

That silence again.

The kind that felt like it had weight.

Then Mia said softly:

“People only see what they’re looking for.”

She frowned. “That sounds like nonsense.”

Mia smiled. “Most truths do.”

That night, she went through her phone again.

Not looking for Mia.

Looking for *proof of today*.

The café receipt.

The second cup.

Anything.

But there was nothing.

Only one transaction.

One drink.

One seat in the photo she took.

She zoomed in.

The chair across from her was slightly out of focus again.

Always slightly wrong.

She whispered to herself:

“I remember two.”

From behind her:

“Memory isn’t always attendance.”

She turned.

Mia was sitting on her bed.

Calm.

Familiar.

But something about her felt quieter tonight.

Less playful.

More... careful.

“You’re tired,” Mia said softly.

“I’m not confused.”

Mia nodded.

“I didn’t say you were.”

Silence.

Then she asked:

“Why did you tell me not to let anyone order for me?”

Mia looked at her.

Longer this time.

Then said:

“Because some choices don’t come back once they’re made for you.”

She frowned. “That doesn’t answer anything.”

Mia smiled faintly.

“It’s not meant to.”

She lay down that night with the feeling that something had shifted.

Not broken.

Not revealed.

Just shifted.

Like a picture on the wall slightly off-center.

Mia was still there.

Still normal.

Still joking when she needed to be.

But now—

there were moments where she felt less like a friend...

and more like something carefully standing between her and something else.

And for the first time,

she wondered not just who Mia was—

but what Mia was protecting her from noticing.

End of Chapter 4